

Governance With a Heartbeat

A Practical Toolkit for Assumption-Led Governance

Change rarely fails because nobody was paying attention.

It fails because we were paying attention to the wrong things.

This toolkit is a simple discipline for keeping governance connected to reality.

It is not an additional layer of process. It is a way of sharpening what already exists.

The aim is straightforward:

- Make assumptions visible.
 - Test them with evidence.
 - Adapt early.
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Why This Exists

Most governance frameworks are strong on structure:

- Clear roles
- Clear reporting
- Clear approval gates

What they are weaker on is timing.

Between approval and delivery, assumptions quietly age.

Some strengthen. Some decay. A few expire.

This toolkit helps boards, sponsors and delivery leads notice that decay early enough to act.

The Governance Evidence Loop

Three artefacts. Nothing more.

1. Decision Ledger
2. Evidence Signals
3. Adaptation Record

Used together, they create a loop rather than a checkpoint.

1. Decision Ledger

Govern what must remain true.

Every material decision is recorded with its underlying assumptions.

Decision ID	Decision Authorised	Date	Explicit Assumptions (What must remain true?)	Tolerances (Cost/Time/Risk/Impact)	Assumption Owner	Review Frequency
D-001	Approve Phase 2 build	12/03/26	Adoption $\geq$ 70% within 3 months; Data accuracy $\geq$ 95%; Political support sustained	$\pm$ 10% budget; $\leq$ 4 week slip	Sponsor	Monthly

Key discipline

- No significant decision without explicit assumptions
- No assumption without an owner
- No owner without a review rhythm

This is not about predicting the future.

It is about making the conditions for success visible.

2. Evidence Signals

Detect assumption drift early.

For each major decision, define a small set of signals that would indicate weakening assumptions.

Keep it focused. Five to ten signals only.

Decision ID	Assumption Being Tested	Evidence Signal	Threshold	Current Trend	Status	Commentary
D-001	Adoption $\geq$ 70%	Weekly active users	$<$ 55% for 3 consecutive weeks	Falling	Amber	Training gap emerging

Signal design principles

- Prefer leading indicators over lagging outcomes
- Define thresholds in advance
- Include at least one user or service-facing measure
- Review signals periodically to avoid drift

The purpose is not surveillance.

It is clarity.

3. Adaptation Record

Governance must change something.

At each governance cycle, ask:

Have any assumptions weakened enough to require adaptation?

Review Date	Decision ID	Signal Triggered?	Adaptation Decision	Rationale	Next Evidence Focus
18/04/26	D-001	Yes	Extend training sprint; intensify adoption monitoring	Early decay detected	Add user satisfaction pulse

If a decision changes, record it.

If it does not change, record why.

This creates a visible link between evidence and authority.

Minimal Operating Rules

You can run this at portfolio, programme or project level.

1. Every material approval states what must remain true
2. Evidence signals are defined at the time of approval
3. Each governance meeting explicitly considers assumption health
4. Adaptations are recorded, not implied

That is all.

What This Is Not

It is not:

- A replacement for risk management
- A substitute for audit
- An additional reporting burden

It is a way of sharpening governance so that oversight remains connected to reality between checkpoints.

When This Works Best

- Complex digital change

- Multi-supplier environments
- Behavioural transformation
- Politically sensitive programmes
- AI-enabled services

In these contexts, certainty is lower and interdependence is higher.
Assumptions move faster than paperwork.

A Quiet Reflection

If governance only discovers failure when reversal is expensive, it is already too late.

The Governance Evidence Loop is a small discipline designed to shorten that distance.

It does not require new committees.

It requires clarity and courage.
